UNIT V - LISTENING SKILLS AND NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

1. Importance of Listening

Listening is the most used communication skill. Good listening helps us understand instructions, learn, build relationships, avoid mistakes and respond properly. **Hearing** is a physical ability; **listening** is the active effort to understand meaning.

2. Basics of Listening

- **Stages:** receiving - understanding - remembering - evaluating - responding.
- **Types:** appreciative (enjoying music or a story), informational (learning a lecture), critical (judging an argument), empathetic (understanding feelings).
- **Active listening:** look at the speaker, do not interrupt, nod or say 'I see', ask questions, and repeat key points in your own words.

3. Barriers to Listening

Type	Examples
Physical	Noise, poor sound quality, uncomfortable room
Psychological	Stress, anger, worry, prejudice, lack of interest
Language	Unfamiliar words, heavy accent, fast speech
Attention	Daydreaming, thinking of a reply, using a phone
Information overload	Too much information at once

4. Listening for Gist, Style and Tone

- **Gist:** the main idea or general meaning. Ask: What is this mainly about?
- **Style:** how the message is expressed, formal or informal, simple or technical, friendly or serious.
- **Tone:** the speaker's attitude or feeling, such as angry, sad, sarcastic, cheerful or neutral. Tone is shown through pitch, pace and volume.

5. Voice Recording Exercises

- Record yourself reading a passage or speaking on a topic for one to two minutes.
- Play it back and note pronunciation, pace, pauses, clarity, volume and fillers.
- Re-record after practice and compare. Also record a short talk and write down its gist as a listening task.

6. Body Language

Non-verbal communication is communication without words. Experts commonly say that a large part of the impact of a message comes from tone and body language, so words and body language must match.

7. Importance of Body Language in Communication

- It reinforces, replaces or contradicts spoken words.
- It shows confidence, honesty, interest or nervousness.
- It helps in interviews, presentations, discussions and daily conversation.

8. Gestures, Posture, Eye Contact and Facial Expressions

Element	Meaning and good practice
Gestures	Hand and arm movements to emphasise points. Keep them natural and not distracting; avoid pointing a finger.
Posture	Stand or sit straight with shoulders relaxed to show confidence and respect. Avoid slouching or crossed arms, which can look closed or bored.
Eye contact	Look at the listener to show honesty and attention. Do not stare; in a group move your eyes across the audience.
Facial expressions	A genuine smile creates warmth. Expression should match the message (serious for serious news).
Proxemics	Use of space and distance. Keep a comfortable distance in conversation.
Paralanguage	Voice qualities such as pitch, pace, volume and pauses.
Haptics	Touch, for example a handshake; a firm, brief handshake is the norm in formal settings.

9. Etiquette

- Be punctual and dress suitably for the occasion.
- Greet politely, use 'please', 'thank you' and 'sorry'.
- Do not interrupt; wait for your turn to speak.
- Keep mobile phones silent and away during meetings and conversations.
- Show respect to all, irrespective of age or position, and be mindful of cultural differences.
- Telephone etiquette: identify yourself, speak clearly, be brief and polite, and thank the caller.

Recommended Reading

- Balan, K.R. and Rayudu, C.S. *Effective Communication*. Beacon, 1996.
- Howard, Peter. *Perfect Your Punctuation*. Orient Longman, Delhi, 1997.
- Lewis, Norman. *Word Power Made Easy*. Penguin Publishers, 2015.
- McCarthy, Michael and Felicity O'Dell. *English Vocabulary in Use: Advanced*. Cambridge University Press, 2008.
- Mohan Krishna and Banerji, Meera. *Developing Communication Skills*. Macmillan, 1990.
- Quirk, Randolph and Greenbaum, Sidney. *A University Grammar of English*. Longman, 1973.
- Wren, P.C. and Martin, H. *High School English Grammar and Composition*. Blackie Books, 2011.